

9
THE QUEST BEGINS

IN RETROSPECT, I'm one of the few who played the game and just kept going. Most cricketers quit after a decade. I got two solid ones in.

It's been over twenty years at the international level and I'm still playing – now in other limited-overs formats. I praise God for giving me the strength and good health to continue. There were several occasions when I wanted to stop. There were times when my body wanted me to stop. There were moments when my hand–eye coordination was all out of place. There were days when I looked at my daughters – Aqsa, Ansha, Ajwa and Asmara – and only wanted to spend more time with them. There was also that terrible phase after my father passed away.

Thankfully, these were all moments that came and went. (By the way, I still try to spend all the time I can with my children.)

After my debut series in Kenya, everything – the attention, the cricket, the energy and the zing – went into overdrive. Next up that winter was a triangular series Down Under featuring Australia, West Indies and Pakistan – the Carlton and United Series. It would be my first tour of Australia.

The Mark Taylor–led Australia side that year had made it to the finals of the World Cup but were in trouble in that series. They won their first couple of games and then things went south. So, it was the West Indies we met in the double-final. Their performance had been the exact opposite of the Aussies: they lost their first couple of games, and then pulled up their socks and surged ahead to take us and the Aussies head-on.

As for Pakistan, we were either terrible or brilliant – the usual traits in our cricket. That series was the first time I bowled my faster one – I think Greg Blewett was the first victim – and the Aussie commentators were all over me. My batting in the series – I was 'Man of the Finals' – earned me the name 'Kid Dynamite' in the Australian press, way before India's Ravi Shastri coined the more permanent 'Boom Boom'. But clearly, it was Saqlain Mushtaq who dominated the series and introduced his own version of the *doosra*, the one that spun the other way, years